One Wilfred, a tall and very outgoing black American, who had spent about seven and a half years in jail as an undertrial, confirmed Gupta's statement:

> These guys, belonging to gangs, would go up to the medical officer. There'd be the deputy jailer and other prison staff there too and prisoners queued up to get their medicines. But these guys would tell them to get out and then they'd take whatever and however much medicines they wanted – mostly diazepams – and nobody would do or say anything.

Ex-superintendent of jails, Jagdish Prasad Naithani, looked back over the years and tried to explain the reasons behind such a situation:

> There are always two classes of prisoners in jails, the haves and the have-nots. Some of the haves in Tihar were powerful criminals who still wielded influence outside. They generated a fear of money and muscle and even the staff [members] were intimidated by them. Fear, and greed for easy money, made the staff blind to the ugly goings-on. Added to this was overcrowding and, therefore, there was a much increased contact between prisoners. That's why there were so many prison offences and without formal complaints. Tihar had been administered as an additional charge of the District Commissioner of Police till as late as 1979–80. The staff was by and large inducted from the ranks of the Punjab and Haryana Police. The jail itself had a skeleton prison cadre staff mostly in the form of wardens and their assistants. Internecine departmental rivalries and jealousies were rampant and this told on the quality of administration. Unlike other state prisons in the country the judiciary held a lot of influence over the jail's administration. Penalties incurred by the staff for infraction of rules and duties were inquired into by the lower courts, where cases lingered on endlessly. The prisoners were quick to encash on this and almost on a regular basis the jail staff was defending itself in court on flimsy and falsely levelled charges. The staff got their own back in the only possible way they could, which was to create as inhospitable and as inhuman a climate as they could get away with.

Anne, a Nigerian student of Delhi University, shuddered at the memory of events when she was sent to prison some five years ago:

> When I came here I wanted to die. The conditions were so bad. I thought some of the prisoners were mad and we were all thrown in together. We were given regular beatings. I don't know Hindi, so I could not explain what I was asked and then I got punishments.
>
> I was embarrassed. I asked myself, what am I doing here?

Bhupinder Singh Jarial (of the prison's cadre) and the then deputy superintendent of Jail 3 maintained that a lack of motivation amongst senior officers had been largely responsible for the terrible state of affairs in the past:

> The tragedy of the department has been that it has always remained a headless body. Prisons is a state subject and every state must have its own management cadre. No system can be run without the involvement of technical experts. Not just anyone can run the show. For that a particular type of mental attitude and behaviour has to be developed first.
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> Tihar was under the administration of the Punjab … Government till 30 October 1966 on which date the Delhi Administration took over. Yet, till 1981 the same hand-tomouth policy